

Overview: Prompt Fading

Prompt fading is the art of gradually withdrawing support so smoothly that the pupil doesn't notice—and suddenly they're doing something independently that they previously needed help with. You start with maximum support (physical guidance, full verbal prompts, complete models), then systematically reduce it over time: from hand-over-hand to hand-on-shoulder; from full sentences to single words to just a look. The goal is independence, achieved without the cliff-edge of suddenly removing all help.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil succeeds with support but stops the moment adult moves away
- Always waits for instruction before starting, even familiar tasks
- Asks "Is this right?" after every step
- Can do the skill but only when prompted each time
- Other staff report different levels of independence

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify the target skill

Be specific. "Use a sentence starter independently" not "do English." The skill must be something they CAN do with support—you are fading scaffolding, not teaching from scratch.

Teacher says: N/A - this is planning

Tip: Choose high-impact skills: routines, core academic tasks, self-regulation strategies.

2 Determine current prompt level

What support do they need RIGHT NOW to succeed? If unsure, start higher—it is easier to fade down than to rescue failure. Use the hierarchy: Physical (P), Model (M), Verbal Direct (VD), Verbal Indirect (VI), Gestural (G), Visual (V), Independent (I).

Tip: Observe across multiple instances before deciding. One success does not mean they are ready to fade.

3 Plan your hierarchy for this skill

Write out what each prompt level looks like for THIS specific skill. What is the physical prompt? What is the model? What words for verbal direct vs indirect? What gesture will you use?

Teacher says: "For using sentence starters: Physical = I guide their hand to the word wall. Model = I write the starter, they copy. Verbal direct = I say the full starter. Verbal indirect = I say just the first word. Gestural = I point to the wall. Visual = the wall itself. Independent = nothing."

Tip: Write this on a Post-it or tracking sheet so all staff are consistent.

4 Get 3 successes at current level

Before fading, the pupil must succeed THREE times in a row at the current prompt level. This is not negotiable. Three ensures it was not a fluke.

Tip: For tricky skills or anxious pupils, increase to 5 or 7 successes.

5 Fade by one level

Move up the hierarchy by exactly one step. From verbal direct to verbal indirect. From gestural to visual. Never skip levels.

Teacher says: "Yesterday I said the full sentence starter. Today I'll just say the first word and see if they can continue."

Tip: If the gap feels too big, add an intermediate step (e.g., verbal direct + gesture, then gesture only).

6 If they fail, drop back immediately

No drama, no disappointment. Just smoothly return to the previous level. Try fading again after more successes.

Teacher says: "Let me help you with that one." [Provide previous level prompt]

Tip: Failure at a new level means 3 more successes at the old level before trying again.

7 Track and communicate

Record current level and date. Share with all staff working with this pupil. Everyone must use the SAME prompt level.

Tip: A simple tracking card that travels with the pupil works well.

English Example: Using analytical sentence starters

Year 9 English class analysing Macbeth. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to use "The writer suggests..." independently.

Week 1: Model level

Teacher: Write "The writer suggests that Macbeth is..." on the board. Say: "Watch me write my analysis sentence. Now you copy this starter and finish it with your own idea."

Pupil: Copies sentence starter from board. Adds own ending. Succeeds 3 times.

Week 2: Verbal direct level

Teacher: Say: "Start your sentence with 'The writer suggests that...' and tell me what the writer suggests about this character."

Pupil: Writes sentence starter from verbal prompt. Completes sentence. Succeeds 3 times.

Week 3: Verbal indirect level

Teacher: Say: "Begin your analysis sentence. The writer..." then pause expectantly.

Pupil: Continues "...suggests that..." and completes sentence. Succeeds 3 times.

Week 4: Gestural level

Teacher: Point to sentence starter poster on wall. Say nothing.

Pupil: Looks at poster, writes "The writer suggests..." independently.

Week 5: Independent

Teacher: Say: "Analyse the next quote." Give no sentence starter prompt.

Pupil: Writes "The writer suggests..." without any prompt. Poster still available as backup.

Maths Example: Solving two-step equations

Year 8 Maths class solving equations like $2x + 3 = 11$. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to solve these independently.

Stage 1: Model level

Teacher: Solve the equation on the board while narrating each step. "First I deal with the +3 by subtracting 3 from both sides. Then I deal with the 2x by dividing both sides by 2." Say: "Now you copy exactly what I did with this next one."

Pupil: Copies the method exactly. Teacher checks and confirms. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 2: Verbal direct level

Teacher: Say: "First, what operation do you need to undo? The +3. So subtract 3 from both sides. Write that. Good. Now divide both sides by 2."

Pupil: Follows each verbal instruction. Writes solution step by step. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 3: Verbal indirect level

Teacher: Say: "What do you do first with a two-step equation? Deal with the..." and pause.

Pupil: Says "...number on its own" and subtracts 3. Continues to divide by 2. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 4: Gestural level

Teacher: Point to the steps poster showing "1. Deal with the number. 2. Deal with the letter." Say nothing.

Pupil: Follows steps from poster. Solves equation correctly. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 5: Independent

Teacher: Say: "Solve this equation." Give no additional prompt. Poster remains on wall.

Pupil: Solves $2x + 5 = 13$ independently using internalised steps.

Science Example: Writing a hypothesis

Year 7 Science class planning an investigation. Pupil working at KS1 level needs to write a hypothesis using "I predict... because..."

Stage 1: Physical + Model level

Teacher: Write hypothesis frame on pupil's sheet: "I predict _____ because _____."
Guide their hand to underline the frame. Say: "I'll write one first. I predict the plant will grow taller because it has more light. Now you write yours in the same way."

Pupil: Copies the structure. Writes own hypothesis with physical guidance to the frame.

Stage 2: Verbal direct level

Teacher: Say: "Write your hypothesis. Start with 'I predict' then say what you think will happen. Then write 'because' and say why."

Pupil: Writes hypothesis following verbal instructions. "I predict the ice will melt because it is warm."

Stage 3: Verbal indirect level

Teacher: Say: "Write your hypothesis. Remember, I predict... because..."

Pupil: Uses the partial verbal cue to structure their writing. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 4: Gestural level

Teacher: Point to hypothesis frame on the Science Working Wall. Raise eyebrows expectantly.

Pupil: Looks at frame, writes hypothesis in correct format. Succeeds 3 times.

Stage 5: Independent

Teacher: Say: "Write your hypothesis for this investigation."

Pupil: Writes "I predict... because..." without any prompt. Frame still visible as environmental support.